

QA LEADERSHIP ACADEMY

Release Risk Communication Template

Present residual release risk so the accountable business owner can make an informed go/no-go — QA informs, the business owns the call.

Purpose

Whether to ship is a business decision, not a QA decision. QA's job is to make the residual risk visible, honest and understandable so that the person accountable for the outcome can decide with their eyes open. This template gives you a repeatable way to communicate that risk at a release gate, and — just as importantly — to make explicit who owns the go/no-go.

The distinction is the whole point. "Residual risk" is what remains untested, unresolved or uncertain at the moment of decision. QA reports it; the accountable business owner accepts it or not. When QA quietly makes the call, QA absorbs blame that was never theirs to carry, and the business is denied a decision that is rightfully its own.

When to use it

- At every release go/no-go gate, especially where risk is non-trivial.
- When testing is incomplete at the decision point and someone must decide whether to proceed anyway.
- When you are under pressure to "sign off" on a release you have concerns about.
- For any release touching high-blast-radius areas — payments, billing, authentication, data.

Instructions

1. State the release, the date and — explicitly — who owns the go/no-go decision. Name the person, not a team.
2. Summarise what was tested and, crucially, what was not. Coverage gaps are the heart of residual risk.
3. For each residual risk, describe the possible impact in business terms and your best sense of likelihood.
4. Give your QA recommendation, then stop. Recommending is your job; deciding is the owner's.
5. List any mitigations available — feature flags, phased rollout, extra monitoring, a rollback plan — so the owner has options beyond a binary yes/no.
6. Record the decision, who made it, and the risk they explicitly accepted. This protects everyone and creates an honest audit trail.

The line QA must hold, stated plainly:

QA INFORMS, THE BUSINESS OWNS THE DECISION

QA does not "approve" or "sign off" a release in the sense of owning the consequences. QA makes the risk transparent and recommends. The accountable business owner accepts the residual risk and decides to ship or not. Keep these roles distinct in every communication — it protects the integrity of the decision and the fairness of the accountability.

Worked example

Release risk summary for a payments-adjacent release at Northstar Digital, prepared by the QA lead for the go/no-go. Tom Fielding (Head of Product) is the accountable owner for this feature's release.

Field	Entry
Release	Payments — "save card for later" feature, build 2.7.0
Target date	Friday this week
Go/no-go owner	Tom Fielding, Head of Product (accountable). QA advises; Tom decides.
Tested and passing	Happy-path save-and-reuse on web; card validation; existing checkout regression (core paths).
NOT tested / gaps	Two of four payments critical paths (refund-after-save; save during a failed first charge). Interaction with the legacy billing service. Mobile save-card flow only smoke-tested — staging instability blocked full coverage this cycle.

Residual risk	Possible business impact	Likelihood	QA view
Refund-after-save path untested	Customer charged or refunded incorrectly; support load; trust damage	Medium	Would not ship this path as-is
Legacy billing interaction untested	Billing discrepancies in the monolith; hard to detect quickly	Medium	High blast radius — recommend covering or flagging off
Mobile flow only smoke-tested	Broken save-card on a growing mobile user base	Low-Medium	Acceptable if monitored closely post-release

QA recommendation

Do not ship the refund-after-save and failed-first-charge paths on Friday. Two options let the date hold: (A) feature-flag those paths off and ship the rest Friday; or (B) a two-day slip to cover both critical paths and the legacy billing interaction. QA recommends Option A as the best balance of date and safety.

Mitigations available

- Feature-flag the untested payments paths off at launch.
- Phased rollout: enable for a small percentage of users first.
- Heightened monitoring and alerting on billing discrepancies for 72 hours.
- Tested, rehearsed rollback plan for build 2.7.0.

Decision record

Field	Entry
Decision	(to be completed by the owner at the gate)

Field	Entry
Decided by	Tom Fielding
Risk explicitly accepted	(e.g. "Ship Friday with refund-after-save flagged off; accept the smoke-tested mobile flow under 72-hour monitoring")
Date / attendees	

Why this is the right shape: QA has made the gaps and their business impact undeniable, offered options so the decision is not a naked yes/no, recommended clearly — and then handed the decision, and the accepted risk, to the person accountable for the outcome. If the accepted risk later bites, the record shows it was an informed business decision, not a QA failure.

Blank reusable version

Field	Entry
Release	
Target date	
Go/no-go owner (named, accountable)	
Tested and passing	
NOT tested / coverage gaps	

Residual risk	Possible business impact	Likelihood (H/M/L)	QA view

Field	Entry
QA recommendation	
Mitigations available	
Decision	
Decided by (name)	
Risk explicitly accepted	
Date / attendees	

Common mistakes

COMMON MISTAKES

Letting QA "sign off" the release and thereby quietly own a business decision — and the blame when it goes wrong. Reporting only what was tested and staying silent on the gaps, which is where the real risk lives. Presenting a binary go/no-go with no mitigations, so the owner feels cornered into overruling you. Describing risk in technical terms the business owner cannot weigh. Softening the risk to keep the peace

under deadline pressure. And failing to record who decided and what risk they accepted, leaving accountability to be argued about after an incident.

How to interpret / use it well

- Name the owner every time. If no one will own the decision, that vacuum is itself the biggest risk — surface it.
- Lead with the gaps. What you did not test is more decision-relevant than what you did.
- Offer mitigations so the choice is rarely a naked binary. Feature flags and phased rollout often let the date and the safety both survive.
- Recommend without deciding. Your credibility comes from clear advice, not from taking a call that is not yours.
- Keep the decision record. It is not bureaucracy — it is what makes the QA-informs / business-owns split real and fair.
- Pair with the Difficult Conversation Planner when you expect the owner to push back on an uncomfortable recommendation.

INSIDE STLC PRO TIP

Never say "QA signs off the release." Say "QA has surfaced the residual risk; the business owner decides to accept it or not." That single change of language protects your team from carrying decisions that were never theirs — and, paradoxically, it makes executives trust QA more, because you are visibly not gaming the outcome.